western city of Herat (Figure I.23), appearing as natural proscenia upon which great histories unfolded.

But such modern fetishism actually distracts from the long-standing reality of these eastern parts of the Islamic-Persianate world. The regions within modern Afghanistan were collectively a busy place, being *the* strategic areas for control of much of Eurasia, as realized by the Sasanians, various Hunnic groups such as the Hephthalites, and the Western Turks – to name only a few who built and consolidated empires starting and sometimes ending there. Moreover, the picturesque but artificially empty vistas occlude the multifarious iterations of the above-mentioned nomad–urban continuum prevailing throughout the vast majority of the Iranian cultural world, including Afghanistan, well into the nineteenth century. The protagonists in forging imperial formations were not solely the regions' magnificent landscapes; they combined with enterprising populations, which spanned the nomad–urban continuum, to link the Iranian and Indic cultural spheres. Overall, it is to a more complete apprehension of this dynamism that the ensuing project is dedicated.

Notes

1. Translated by J. Stephenson 1911: 13. On this British officer in the Indian Medical Service and his early study of Sana'i's extremely complex *Hadiqat* (including the work's codicological history), see de Bruijn 1983: 122; and Allegranzi 2019a, vol. I: 29–30.
2. According to Lewis (1995: 120), it was Sana'i who first introduced the Buddhist parable of the blind men and the elephant into the literature of the Persianate world, a parable thereafter incorporated into the works of al-Ghazali (AH 450–505/1058–1111 CE), Jalal al-Din Rumi (d. AH 671/1273 CE), and others. Cf. also de Bruijn, "Sana'i" *EIr* (2012); but cf. also note *infra*.
3. Although "*Udana*" characterized a variety of Buddhists texts, principally in Pali, here the reference is to the third book of the *Khuddakanikaya*, which contained eighty stories and utterances of the Buddha. The utterances were mostly in verse, accompanied by prose accounts of the circumstances prompting them. The Buddhist elephant parable was predictably situated within the sacred geography of early Buddhism, so that the king referred to in the text ruled at Shravasti (Pal. Savatthi), where he summoned "all the men born blind in Savatthi" to describe an elephant. During the historical Buddha's lifetime (mid-first millennium CE), Shravasti was the capital of the powerful Koshala kingdom, located in the foothills of the Himalayas of modern Nepal. Cf. Buswell and Lopez 2014: 42, 383, 435, 443, 932; see also the English translation of the Pali *Udana* by D. M. Strong (1902: 93–96).
4. Thomas de Bruijn, among the principal scholars of Sana'i, described *Hadiqat* as "one of the most problematic works of Persian literature" for Western scholars, though in the Persian ecumene it has enjoyed a favored status over the centuries, providing "a promising source for the study of indigenous